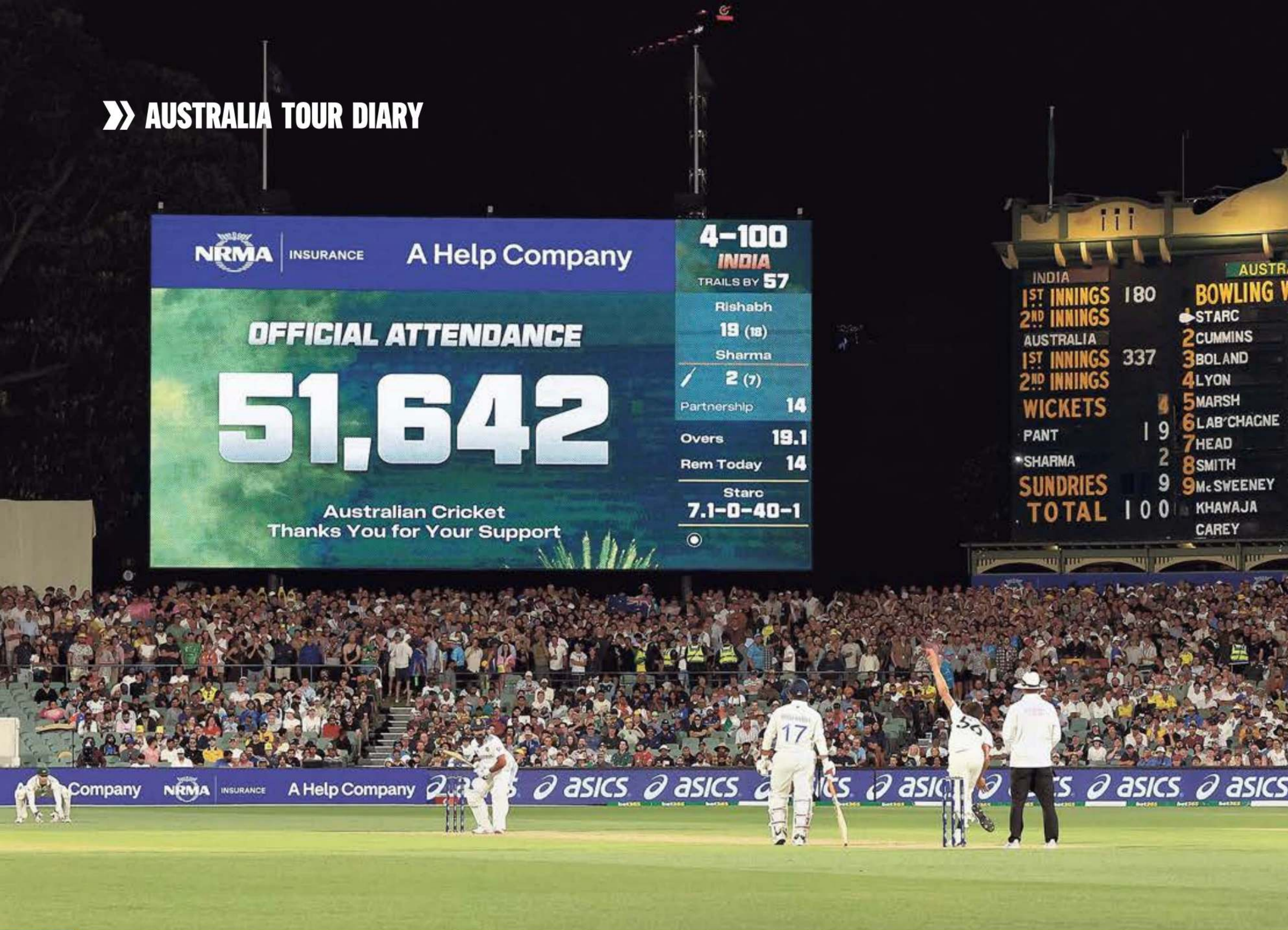




A WARM-UP DONE WELL

There is a **charm to Adelaide** that is about long pauses, deep breaths, and the slow life.

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Canberra is a capital with a twin shade. Seat of power, yes; a sleepy rural vibe, yes again! And on December 1, finally, a game gets underway at the Manuka Oval. The warm-up fixture between the Indians and the Prime Minister's XI becomes a limited-overs affair, and Rohit Sharma's men prevail by six wickets.

Young Sam Konstas catches the eye with a 107, while India chases 240 but stretches to 257 for an extended batting stint. Shubman Gill, returning from injury, scores a 50, while Rohit, after a paternity break, departs cheaply.

But he is in good spirits as he gets the trophy and flexes it towards his team-mates.

The interlude is over, and it is time to head to Adelaide as the Border-Gavaskar Trophy series wends towards the second Test. Scott Boland is on the flight — a tall but silent presence. At

Adelaide airport, he gets a cab, piles in his baggage and cricket kitbag. No fuss, just another bloke on an official trip.

The easy vibe

There is a charm to Adelaide that is about long pauses, deep breaths, and the slow life. The mood sets in as the flight circles around the sea. Bharat Sundaresan, an Indian cricket writer now settled Down Under, invites a few to his abode in the hills. A ride up through the twisting roads past vineyards is soothing to the eye. A night of banter and a slow dinner ensues while Sunil Gavaskar and Ravi